
Calming Anxiety and Overwhelm

When the wave rises: returning to the present

4 psychology approaches · by EvaTalk

TO BEGIN

When the wave rises: returning to the present

When anxiety or emotion overwhelms you, your nervous system goes into alarm mode: it seems endless, the heart races, thoughts spiral. Yet an emotion is a wave — it rises, peaks, then falls.

This guide helps you ride the wave by returning to the present, instead of fighting it.

YOUR INTENTION

What overwhelms you most (anxiety, panic, overload) and how it shows up: _____

Emotion is a wave

Overwhelm is excess activation: the body prepares for danger (real or imagined). It seems endless, but no emotion lasts forever at its peak: it crests then falls. And the body can be helped to come down.

Knowing 'it will peak then pass' keeps you from panicking about panicking.

Example

Léa thought her anxiety would never stop; understanding the wave helped her let it pass.

The wave

How do you recognize your wave rising (body, thoughts)?

It passes

Write: 'An emotion peaks, then it falls.'

Takeaway — Emotion is a wave: it peaks, then it falls.

'I'll lose control'

'I'll lose control', 'it'll never stop', 'something terrible will happen to me': these thoughts, typical of anxiety, feed the wave.

Reframing them ('it's uncomfortable, not dangerous') makes it fall faster.

Example

'I'm going crazy' terrified Sami, until he saw the discomfort wasn't a danger.

Spot the thought

Note an anxious thought that amplifies the wave · a fairer version.

Uncomfortable ≠ dangerous

Write: 'It's uncomfortable, not dangerous.'

Takeaway — Anxiety lies about danger: it's uncomfortable, rarely dangerous.

Don't fight yourself

Fighting anxiety ('stop, calm down!') adds tension. Compassion ('this is hard right now, I'm with myself') and accepting the wave make it less frightening. You aren't in danger of being overwhelmed.

What we accept to feel passes faster than what we fight.

Example

By stopping fighting her panic, Nia saw it subside far faster.

With me

What gentle sentence could you tell yourself at the heart of the wave?

Accept the wave

Write: 'I let the wave pass, I'm with myself.'

Takeaway — Don't fight the wave: accepting it soothes it faster.

Grounding and breathing

In practice, to return to the present: 5-sense grounding (name 5 things you see, 4 you hear, 3 you touch), long-exhale breathing (breathe out more slowly than you breathe in), and naming ('right now, this is anxiety'). If anxiety is frequent or intense, a professional truly helps.

Grounding brings your attention to the present, where the danger isn't.

Example

By grounding through his 5 senses at the first signs, Karim defused the wave before its peak.

My grounding

Your favorite grounding or breathing technique: _____

To the present

Write: 'I return to the present: that's where I'm safe.'

Takeaway — 5-sense grounding + long exhale + naming: return to the present.

Key takeaways

- Emotion is a wave: it peaks, then it falls.
- Overwhelm is excess activation, not a real danger.
- Anxiety lies about danger: it's uncomfortable, rarely dangerous.
- Don't fight the wave: accepting it soothes it faster.
- Ground through the 5 senses and breathe with a long exhale.
- If anxiety is frequent or intense, a professional helps.

Your turn

My wave

How I recognize it	The anxious thought

My grounding

My gentle sentence	My grounding technique

YOUR JOURNEY

Your 4-week plan

Week 1

Understand that emotion is a wave.

Week 2

Reframe 'I'll lose control'.

Week 3

Accept the wave instead of fighting.

Week 4

Ground through the 5 senses and breathing.

YOUR PLAN

Your action plan

My 'uncomfortable, not dangerous' line:

How I recognize my wave:

My grounding technique:

The wave always rises and falls — ground yourself, and let it pass.

This guide is a coaching and psychoeducation tool, not therapy. If your emotions overwhelm you persistently or strongly affect your life, a professional (psychologist) can help. © PerfectMatch · EvaTalk.